

closely, felt so much worse than a one-sided defeat. The most important thing is that we were all one as a team. We didn't sit and assign blame. Something similar happened during this campaign, too. We were just looking ahead."

Another heartbreak involving Deepti unfolded in the 2022 World Cup, in a must-win league clash against South Africa in Christchurch. Defending six runs in the final over, Deepti overstepped, handing Mignon du Preez a lifeline that eventually helped South Africa secure the win and a place in the semifinal.

The regret consumed her. "I remember, Jhulu di (Jhulan Goswami) and Mithali (Raj) were also playing probably their final game. That made me feel worse that I couldn't see the team through. I can't describe how bad I felt."

Watching such magnificent ODI careers end in a whimper kept her awake for a long time.

"A home World Cup, the occasion was not lost on us this time. We know we might never get a chance to script something as perfectly as this. Four years later, who knows where we will be?"

When the same team stood between India and glory again, Deepti did not miss. She scored a defiant run-a-ball 58 to help India reach 298, then took five wickets, including the prized scalp of Proteas captain and centurion Laura Wolvaardt, to help India finally cross the line in an ICC event.

"Memories of 2022 crossed my mind, but it was important to forget whatever happened before and go again. I was able to do what I missed the last time."

This campaign saw Deepti repeatedly thrown into sticky situations, asked to drag India out of quicksand, a job that came with its share of stumbles. She registered the most expensive bowling figures in a Women's World Cup knockout match when she conceded 73 runs in the semifinal against Australia. Yet nothing fazed her. She had promised her brother that '*is baar jeetke hi ayenge* (will win and come this time)'.



**Historic symmetry:** Deepti opened her tournament with a fifty and a three-wicket haul, and closed it with a fifty and a five-wicket masterclass, the first time any cricketer in any World Cup final, women's or men's, has done so.

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Everything else could wait.

"I'm not a big thinker," she says, a learned departure from the overthinking teenager she once was.

"I read the situation and play, which is quite difficult because you can't always execute what you want to do every time. When the team wins after you perform as an all-rounder, it's a different feeling."

It's no surprise that coach Amol Muzumdar made it a habit to call Deepti '*Stokesy*' when he took over in 2023.

"He gave me that name because

of the power I have in my arm. I like it. He used to call me that in the nets, meetings, or during drills. He would say, 'I don't need to tell her what to do. She'll handle it.' It gave me so much confidence. I kept talking to myself about the things I had given him faith about as a player."

#### **Forged in fire**

Deepti will be the first to insist that her on-field aggression is not anger. She considers herself calm and industrious once she steps past the boundary rope.

"There's a maturity to her now,